

Ridgewood High School

4200 W. Broad Street, Columbus, OH 43204

Patricia Nelson, AP English Literature

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To the Admissions Committee,

It is a genuine privilege to recommend Gerald Ellison. I have taught for nineteen years, and I have had perhaps a handful of students who write the way Gerald does, with a quiet honesty that cannot be coached. I taught him in AP English Literature this year, and I have watched him in the hallways and on stage for longer than that.

Gerald is the rare student who listens more than he speaks and is sharper for it. In seminar he waits, takes in the whole room, and then says the one thing that moves the conversation forward. His essay on inheritance and memory, framed around the bluegrass tradition he carries from his grandfather, was the best piece of student writing I read all year. It was unsentimental and earned every line.

What sets him apart is character. He leads the school bluegrass ensemble not by being the loudest talent in the room, though he may be the most gifted, but by pulling younger players forward and giving them the hard parts. He carries real responsibility at home for his younger siblings and never once has used it as an excuse. He holds himself to a standard of honesty that is unusual at any age.

Whatever path Gerald chooses, and I suspect he is still weighing a few, he will bring to it the same seriousness and the same decency. He has my highest recommendation, without reservation.

Sincerely,

Patricia Nelson

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